

# STANFORD GRADUATE SCHOOL OF BUSINESS

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## INSIDER TIPS



# ABOUT STANFORD GSB

“The majority of people who go to GSB do extraordinary things in ordinary jobs.” The Stanford MBA Program is the most selective in the world. It has maintained the highest ratio of applicants to available seats of any business school in the U.S. for the last decade. The Stanford Graduate School of Business has also had the lowest acceptance rates of any major business school in the world. Accepting on average only 6% of those who submit the Stanford GSB application for admission, yield is generally around 93%.

The Stanford MBA class size is less than half the size of Harvard Business School, and lends itself to an intimate and close-knit community environment that pretty much guarantees almost every student knows each other. The Stanford MBA class profile is extremely diverse and changes from year-to-year. With Silicon Valley in its back yard, a growing number of tech and engineering applicants are choosing the GSB over their East coast rival. The dean estimates that a Stanford MBA is the preferred choice for 3 out of every 4 applicants admitted to both HBS and the GSB. With the highest total compensation for alumni five years after school – estimated by Forbes at an average of \$255,000 – and the pick of the hiring options from Google, McKinsey and a thriving Silicon Valley, the school and its graduates are clearly in the right place at the right time.

## **STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS**

As you might expect from one of the world’s top graduate business schools, Stanford’s MBA program is known for its strengths across many areas, in particular entrepreneurship, innovation, general management and social enterprise.

# KEY STATS

## MBA RANKINGS\*

|                  | 2017 | 2018 | 2019 | 2020 | 2021 | 2022 | 2023 |
|------------------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|
| BusinessWeek     | 5    | 1    | 1    | 1    | *    | *    | 1    |
| Financial Times  | 2    | 1    | 1    | 3    | *    | 6    | 4    |
| US News          | 4    | 4    | 2    | 1    | 1    | 1    | 6    |
| Poets and Quants | 3    | 3    | 1    | 1    | 1    | 1    | 3    |

## INCOMING CLASS

|                      |             |                 |     |
|----------------------|-------------|-----------------|-----|
| Number of Applicants | 6,152       | Avg GMAT        | 737 |
| MBA Class Size       | 424         | % International | 37% |
| Total Tuition        | US\$153,180 | % Women         | 44% |
| Avg Work Experience  | 4.9 years   |                 |     |

## POST-MBA CAREERS

|                       |     |
|-----------------------|-----|
| Financial Services    | 33% |
| Technology            | 30% |
| Starting Own Business | 19% |
| Consulting            | 15% |
| Healthcare            | 5%  |

|                              |                    |
|------------------------------|--------------------|
| <b>AVERAGE BASE SALARY:</b>  | <b>US\$175,000</b> |
| <b>SALARY INCREASE:</b>      | <b>131%</b>        |
| <b>EMPLOYED IN 3 MONTHS:</b> | <b>93%</b>         |



# TOP TIPS FOR ACING YOUR STANFORD GSB APPLICATION

**BY MATT SYMONDS**

Considered to be one of the most influential voices in business education, Matt Symonds is the first point of contact for many of our clients and brings a truly unique level of insight to business school selection. Bestselling author of *Getting the MBA Admissions Edge*, sponsored by McKinsey, Goldman Sachs, BCG and Bain, he writes about the MBA for *Forbes*, *The Economist*, *BusinessWeek*, the BBC, and *AméricaEconomía*. His in-depth industry knowledge makes him a much sought after guest on television, radio, in the press and at conferences.



**Rather than indulging in heavy self-promotion to blow away the competition, striking a humble tone with thoughtful illustration is the best way forward.**

# 1

## DEFINING CHANGE

There are not many institutions in the world that can get away with the tagline "Change lives. Change organizations. Change the world." So when it comes to defining your career goals, you should bear in mind that the admissions office is seeking individuals who are looking to have real impact, whether professionally or in society. The selectivity of the business school means that they can look beyond students whose goal is to secure a place in a strategy consulting firm or investment bank, and identify those applicants who are driven by a desire not just to excel in their careers but also to help others and have a positive impact. As you think about your own post-MBA career goals, include a longer-term view about the areas where you think you can affect real change.

## YIELD AND THE IMPORTANCE OF FIT

# 2

A yield above 80% suggests that the GSB admissions team is very good at identifying those applicants who have a strong fit with the culture and values of the school. Successful applicants not only have academic pedigree, stellar GMAT scores and personal and professional accomplishments to their name. They also have integrity, the ability to open up, be vulnerable, and grow in a supportive yet challenging environment. As such, the Admissions office works very hard to bring together a group of students who are open, humble and have strong integrity and this provides the foundation of the level of camaraderie and trust that you find at the school. Does that sound like you? Then share your story with the school in a natural, genuine way.

# 3

## CAREER GOALS

Pretty much all of the leading business schools can all open the door to McKinsey, Bain, BCG, Goldman and Morgan Stanley. Only 19% of the Stanford Class of 2019 went in to consulting and 5 times as many secured a place in private equity or venture capital as investment banking. Many are starting a new business many of them in the technology sector. The school likes you to dream big while demonstrating that your goals and career vision are viable given your track record of achievement and excellence.

## CONTRIBUTING TO LIFE ON "THE FARM"

# 4

For a program that consistently ranks among the top 2 or 3 in business school rankings, the Stanford MBA does not need to hear from you how wonderful it is. The brand and reputation of the school speak for themselves. But you do need to show your passion and absolute commitment to the school. The admissions team wants to understand how you can contribute to the Stanford community, and how the education you receive will provide the knowledge and skills to make the difference in your career. A campus visit, attending an info session and reaching out to students and alumni are all opportunities to better familiarize yourself with the distinct personality of the school.

So take the time to research the many clubs and organizations available at both the business school and the wider Stanford University campus, 'The Farm', and think about how you can bring energy and engagement outside the MBA classroom. There is no perfect candidate, so be honest about the areas in which you can improve, and how you hope to make the most of your two years in Palo Alto.

# 5

## AUTHENTICITY AND HUMILITY

With 17 applications for each place in the MBA program at the Stanford Graduate School of Business, it is no surprise that candidates feel enormous pressure to stand out in the crowded applicant pool by producing impressive application essays and letters of recommendation for their admissions file.

But you can go too far in a bid to secure your place, and replace authenticity and self-confidence with boastfulness and arrogance. The Assistant Dean of MBA Admissions acknowledges that boastfulness can be an easy trap to fall into when candidates spend their time worrying how they compare to other applicants. But he states that personal humility is not inconsistent with professional ambition and professional drive. And humility is certainly one of the traits the GSB is looking for in its admits.

So while there are many approaches to creating a compelling application, there is clearly an appropriate tone to strike in your application. Rather than pumping up your accomplishments in the hope of impressing the admissions reader, or indulging in heavy self-promotion to blow away the competition, striking a humble tone with thoughtful illustration is the best way forward.

For more insider insights into Stanford GSB  
please visit the [Fortuna Blog](#).

# DEADLINES & DATES

|         | APPLICATION<br>DEADLINE | FINAL DECISIONS  |
|---------|-------------------------|------------------|
| Round 1 | 12 September 2023       | 07 December 2023 |
| Round 2 | 04 January 2024         | 28 March 2024    |
| Round 3 | 09 April 2024           | 23 May 2024      |



**The best time to  
apply is when you're  
ready.**

Caroline Diarte Edwards,  
Co-Founder & Director of Fortuna Admissions

# LET'S GET YOU IN.

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Yale SOM, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://FortunaAdmissions.com)

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

Our free consultations are consistently rated as the best in the industry. To learn more about Fortuna and assess your chances of admission, reserve yours at: [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://FortunaAdmissions.com)

